

notable factor. This significantly reduces the “virality” quotient of a single post, and determines the popularity of an account by the number of followers it has. As a result, having a large following on Instagram involves regularly creating quality content. Third-party apps do enable sharing pictures from other accounts, however.

What sells?

Simply put – visual content/eye candy. It could be the perfectly sculpted body, the ideally planned vacation, the ridiculously serendipitous road trip, or the meticulously plated three-course meal. It is an exercise in image-crafting, with the aim of showing people what their lives could be - that is, show them the versions of their lives in their ideal worlds inside their heads. In other, darker words, it could be called a game of marketers using original content to prey on the insecurities of their target audience and get them hooked onto the dopamine rush offered by the escapism and vicarious pleasure on offer. In some cases, however, this method of crowdfunding validation can lead to some ugly behind-the-scenes situations. More on that later.

Fitness

Instagram is home to a significant number of popular fitness brands like Crossfit and Under Armour. The combination of all-action imagery, active efforts at follower engagement, and of course high quality photography is what makes these accounts popular. Dwayne “The Rock” Johnson (@therock), of WWE fame, is one of the most popular people on Instagram, with over 6 million followers. His feed is a constant stream of intense workout videos, charming stories about his fans, crazy movie-shooting schedules and of course, the legendary cheat meals that he occasionally indulges in. Why does this particular kind of imagery garner such immense attention? It’s inspirational. It tells reminds you that working on your body pays off in spectacular fashion, and seeing physical perfection on your feed is a great boost to both those working towards that aim and those unable to find a starting point alike.

Travel

Travel-oriented Instagram accounts come in all kinds of flavours. Murad Osmann (@muradosmann) showcases the world’s most popular places with a signature composition in his photographs - his wife Natalie holding his